CHAPTER 4

PRIMARY ACTIVITIES

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master economic activities directly dependent on natural resources: hunting, gathering, nomadic herding versus commercial livestock ranching, shifting cultivation, intensive subsistence farming, plantation farming, Mediterranean viticulture, and cooperative versus collective farming models.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Hunting, Gathering, and Pastoralism:** Primitive human subsistence evolved from hunting and gathering to pastoralism. Nomadic herding relies on transhumance across ecological zones, whereas commercial livestock ranching is scientific, permanent, and capital-intensive.

• **Subsistence Agriculture Models:** Primitive subsistence (shifting cultivation or slash-and-burn) uses simple tools and shifting plots. Intensive subsistence farming maximizes yield per unit land using intensive labour, divided into wet paddy dominant and non-paddy systems.

• **Plantation and Commercial Grain Farming:** Plantations are large commercial estates introduced by Europeans producing single export cash crops. Extensive commercial grain farming in mid-latitude grasslands is highly mechanized with massive farm sizes.

• **Mediterranean Agriculture and Farming Organisations:** Mediterranean agriculture is celebrated for specialized viticulture and citrus fruits. Agricultural organization ranges from cooperative societies (voluntary farmer pooling) to collective farming (Soviet Kolkhoz model).

ESSENTIAL GEOGRAPHICAL MODELS & LANDFORMS

$$\text{Nomadic Pastoralism} \iff \text{Subsistence Herding} + \text{Transhumance (Seasonal Migration)}$$
Traditional Pastoral Nomadic Herding Model

$$\text{Commercial Livestock Rearing} \iff \text{Permanent Ranches} + \text{Scientific Breeding} + \text{Capital Intensive}$$
Capitalised Commercial Ranching System

$$\text{Intensive Subsistence Farming} \iff \text{High Yield per Land Area} + \text{Low Output per Labourer}$$
High Land Productivity versus Low Labour Yield

$$\text{Kolkhoz Model} \iff \text{Soviet Collective Farm} \rightarrow \text{Common Land Pooling and State Quotas}$$
Collective Farming Organizational Framework

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** In intensive subsistence farming, yield per unit land area is very high, but yield or productivity per agricultural labourer remains low due to dense rural population pressure.

• **Alert:** Viticulture is a specialized branch of Mediterranean agriculture focusing exclusively on grape cultivation for premium wine and dried raisins.

• **Alert:** Cooperative farming preserves private land ownership while sharing inputs; collective farming (Kolkhoz) converted all private farmland into state-supervised collective property.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Distinguish between Nomadic Herding and Commercial Livestock Rearing. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Nomadic Herding:** Subsistence activity with primitive pastoral techniques; herds move continuously in search of water and pasture; seasonal transhumance is practiced. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Commercial Livestock Rearing:** Specialized, capital-intensive activity conducted on permanent ranches; scientifically managed breeding, feeding, disease control, and meat processing for international markets. **[1.5 Marks]**

2. What is transhumance? Name two pastoral nomadic communities in India that practice transhumance. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** The seasonal migration of pastoral nomadic herders and their livestock between high mountain pastures in summer and low river valleys in winter. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Indian Communities:** The Gujjars, Bakarwals, Gaddis, and Bhotiyas in the Himalayan belt practice seasonal transhumance. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. Describe the main characteristics of shifting cultivation or slash-and-burn agriculture. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Technique:** Forest vegetation is cleared by slashing and burning; ashes are mixed into soil to provide temporary fertility for primitive farming using sticks and hoes. **[1 Mark]**

• **Shifting Plots:** After 3 to 5 years, when soil fertility is exhausted, the plot is abandoned and farmers clear a new forest patch. **[1 Mark]**

• **Regional Names:** Known as Jhuming in Northeast India, Milpa in Central America and Mexico, and Ladang in Malaysia and Indonesia. **[1 Mark]**

4. Explain the distinctive features of Plantation Agriculture with suitable crop examples. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Colonial Genesis:** Introduced by European colonial powers in tropical and subtropical colonies to supply raw cash commodities to home markets. **[1 Mark]**

• **Key Characteristics:** Enormous estate sizes, large capital investment, single crop specialization (monoculture), scientific production techniques, and cheap local labour. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Major Crops and Regions:** Tea in India and Sri Lanka, rubber in Malaysia, coffee in Brazil (fazendas), sugarcane and bananas in the West Indies, and oil palm in West Africa. **[1.5 Marks]**

5. Why is Mediterranean agriculture considered highly specialized and commercially significant? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Viticulture Specialisation:** Mediterranean agriculture is synonymous with viticulture (grape cultivation); superior quality grapes are processed into premium wines, and inferior grapes are dried into raisins. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Citrus and Olive Production:** Region is the foremost producer of citrus fruits (oranges, lemons) and olives, commanding lucrative global market export prices. **[1.5 Marks]**

6. What is truck farming? Explain the origin of this term in agricultural geography. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** Specialized market gardening where farms produce fresh vegetables, fruits, and flowers exclusively for urban consumption. **[1 Mark]**

• **Term Origin:** Termed 'truck farming' because the distance of the agricultural farms from the city market is governed by the distance a truck can traverse overnight. **[1 Mark]**

7. Compare Cooperative Farming with Collective Farming (Kolkhoz), highlighting their operational principles and regional success. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Cooperative Farming:** Farmers pool their land and resources voluntarily while retaining private ownership of their individual holdings; cooperative societies provide fertilizers, machinery, and market access; celebrated success in Denmark, Netherlands, and Sweden. **[2 Marks]**

• **Collective Farming (Kolkhoz):** Introduced in the former Soviet Union; based on social ownership of land and all means of production; private property was abolished, and farmers pooled resources to fulfill state quotas. **[2 Marks]**